

Government Proposal Writing

Best Practices Guide

A field-tested framework for small businesses competing for federal and state contracts — from solicitation release through submission, debrief, and continuous improvement.

1

FOUNDATION

Read the Solicitation — Every Word, Every Page

■ Read the full RFP/RFQ/IFB before doing anything else

Section L tells you how to prepare the proposal. Section M tells you how it will be evaluated. Master both before writing a single word.

■ Create a compliance matrix from Section L

List every requirement, instruction, and deliverable. Map each to a section of your proposal. Missing a required element is an automatic disqualifier.

■ Identify the evaluation criteria and their weights

If Technical is worth 40% and Past Performance 30%, allocate your effort accordingly — write to the scorecard.

■ Note all page limits, font requirements, and formatting rules

Agencies disqualify non-compliant proposals without reading them. Follow every formatting instruction exactly.

■ Flag all questions and submit via the official Q&A; process

Never assume — submit questions during the official question period and monitor amendments to the solicitation.

■ *Pro rule: If it is not in your proposal, it does not exist — the evaluator cannot give you credit for work you did not document.*

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INTELLIGENCE

Understand What the Agency Really Needs

- **Research the agency's mission, strategic goals, and budget priorities**
Align your solution language to the agency's own words. Use their terminology, reference their strategic plan, speak their mission back to them.
- **Review the incumbent's past performance and known weaknesses**
Study USASpending.gov and FPDS for the current contract. Understand what the agency liked and what they did not — then write to fix those gaps.
- **Attend pre-proposal conferences and industry days**
Contracting officers signal priorities at these events. What they emphasize in person often becomes the discriminating factor in evaluation.
- **Review any prior solicitations or RFIs for this requirement**
Prior iterations reveal how the requirement has evolved — and what objections or gaps the agency is trying to solve this time.
- **Identify the end users, not just the contracting officer**
The program office and end users often have more influence on source selection than the CO. Write for the technical evaluator, not the lawyer.
- *Golden rule: The agency does not care about your company — they care about their problem. Show them you understand it better than anyone else.*

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STRATEGY

Develop a Winning Proposal Strategy Before Writing

- **Define your win themes before drafting**
A win theme is a compelling reason why YOUR approach solves THIS agency's problem better than the competition. You should have 3–5 themes that run through every section.
- **Identify your discriminators — what makes you uniquely qualified**
Discriminators are specific, provable advantages: a proprietary tool, a cleared workforce, certified staff, or domain expertise the competition cannot match.
- **Develop a ghost strategy for likely competitors**
Identify who you are competing against. Write your proposal to make their weaknesses visible without naming them — evaluators will draw their own conclusions.
- **Assign a proposal manager and clear roles before kickoff**
Volume leads, reviewers, pricing lead, and a final editor must be identified on day one. Proposals written by committee without ownership fail.
- **Build your proposal schedule working backward from the due date**
Allow time for Pink Team (early draft), Red Team (full review), Gold Team (final review), and a production day. Never submit the first draft.
- *Strategy tip: A proposal without win themes is just a recitation of requirements. Win themes transform compliance into persuasion.*

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WRITING

Write to the Evaluator — Not to Yourself

■ Open every section with your win theme, not your company history

Evaluators read hundreds of pages. Your first sentence must tell them why you win — not when your company was founded.

■ Use the RFP language as your section headers

Mirror the solicitation structure exactly. If Section L says 'Describe your Management Approach,' your header should read 'Management Approach.' Make compliance obvious.

■ Write in active voice with clear, specific, quantified statements

Do not write 'We have extensive experience.' Write 'Our team has delivered 12 similar programs on schedule, averaging 8% under budget.' Numbers win.

■ Eliminate corporate boilerplate and marketing language

Phrases like 'world-class,' 'cutting-edge,' and 'best-in-class' mean nothing to an evaluator. Replace every superlative with a fact, a metric, or a proof point.

■ Use graphics, tables, and visuals to reinforce key messages

A well-placed graphic communicates faster than three paragraphs of text. Use staffing charts, timeline graphics, and process flows — but every visual must have a caption that makes the point.

■ Connect every feature of your solution to a benefit for the agency

Do not just describe what you will do — explain why it matters to them. Feature: dedicated QA manager. Benefit: defects caught before delivery, saving the agency rework time and cost.

■ *Writing rule: Every paragraph should answer one question — 'So what does this mean for the agency?' If it does not, cut it or rewrite it.*

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CREDIBILITY

Past Performance — Prove It, Do Not Just Claim It

■ Select references that are most relevant to this specific requirement

Relevance beats size. A \$500K contract in the same domain is stronger than a \$50M contract in a different field. Match scope, complexity, and customer type.

■ Use the CPAR format: What — So What — Proof

Describe the contract, explain its relevance to this requirement, then provide a specific measurable outcome. Evaluators score relevance and recency — address both explicitly.

■ Quantify every past performance claim

Do not write 'delivered on time.' Write 'delivered all 14 milestones on schedule across a 24-month period of performance with zero corrective action requests.'

■ Notify your references before submission

Call your past performance references before the proposal is due. Confirm their contact information is current and brief them on what the agency may ask.

■ Address any negative past performance proactively

If you have a problematic contract, disclose it and explain corrective actions taken. Evaluators who discover undisclosed issues score you lower than if you had been transparent.

■ *Key principle: Past performance is your credibility on paper. Specificity, recency, and relevance are the three criteria evaluators use — write to all three.*

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PRICING

Price to Win — Competitive, Realistic, and Defensible

■ Build your price from the bottom up, not top down

Start with realistic labor categories, hours, and rates. Add fringe, overhead, G&A, and fee last. A top-down price built to a target is rarely defensible in a BAFO or audit.

■ Use market research to validate your labor rates

Cross-reference GSA Schedule rates, BLS Occupational Wage data, and comparable contract awards to confirm your rates are competitive and reasonable.

■ Understand the difference between realistic and low

Unrealistically low prices trigger scrutiny — agencies can reject proposals for unbalanced pricing. Price to win, not to win at all costs.

■ Align your technical volume with your price volume

Every labor category in your price must appear in your technical approach. Disconnects between the two are red flags for evaluators and contracting officers.

■ Consider your fee strategy relative to contract risk

On firm-fixed-price contracts, fee is baked into your price — it must reflect the risk you are absorbing. On cost-plus, fee is negotiated separately. Know the difference.

■ *Pricing rule: Your price tells a story. Make sure it tells the same story as your technical volume — consistent, credible, and tied to actual work.*

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QUALITY

Review, Review, Review — The Color Team Process

■ Pink Team review at 25–30% complete

Early review of outline, win themes, and draft sections. Purpose: confirm you are on strategy before investing full writing effort. Cheap insurance.

■ Red Team review at 80–90% complete

Full evaluator simulation — assign reviewers who have NOT written the proposal. Score it against Section M. Red Team findings are the most valuable data you will get.

■ Gold Team / Final compliance check before submission

Final check: every Section L requirement addressed, page counts verified, all attachments included, formatting rules met, and all version-control issues resolved.

■ Have a non-expert read the executive summary

If someone unfamiliar with the requirement cannot understand your executive summary in one read, rewrite it. Clarity is a competitive advantage.

■ Never submit without a final production day built into the schedule

Allow one full day for final assembly, PDF conversion, file size checks, and upload testing. Technical submission failures are unrecoverable.

■ *Team rule: The writer is the worst person to review their own work. Build external review into your schedule from day one — not as an afterthought.*

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COMPLIANCE

Compliance — Make It Easy for the Evaluator to Say Yes

■ Use a compliance matrix and check it twice before submission

Every shall, will, and must in the solicitation is a compliance requirement. Your matrix should map each one to a specific page and paragraph in your proposal.

■ State compliance explicitly — do not make evaluators hunt for it

Write 'XYZ Company shall comply with...' at the top of each relevant section. Evaluators cannot give credit for compliance they have to search for.

■ Include all required attachments, forms, and certifications

Commonly missed: SF-1449, SF-330 (for A&E); subcontracting plan, representations and certifications, key personnel resumes, and letters of commitment.

■ Verify file format, naming conventions, and upload portal requirements

Many portals (beta.SAM.gov, eBuy, PIEE) have strict file size limits and naming conventions. A file that fails to upload on deadline day is a lost contract.

■ *Compliance principle: The evaluator's job is to score you — not to find your compliance. Make every requirement easy to locate, easy to verify, and impossible to miss.*

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CONTINUOUS IMPROVEMENT

After Submission — Debrief and Improve

■ Always request a debriefing whether you win or lose

You are legally entitled to a debrief on any competitive acquisition. The feedback is free proposal coaching — use it.

■ Document Red Team and debrief findings in a lessons-learned log

Track recurring weaknesses across proposals. If evaluators consistently say your past performance lacks specificity, that is a process problem to fix.

■ Analyze wins as carefully as losses

Understanding why you won is as important as understanding why you lost. Replicate what worked — do not assume winning was inevitable.

■ Build and maintain a proposal content library

Store approved boilerplate, past performance write-ups, key personnel bios, graphics, and win themes in a shared library. Reuse, refine, and never start from scratch.

■ Track your win rate by contract type, agency, and competition type

If your win rate on unrestricted competitions is low but strong on set-asides, that data should drive your bid/no-bid strategy.

■ *Growth rule: Every proposal — win or lose — is a data point. Companies that debrief, document, and improve compound their win rate over time. Those that do not repeat the same mistakes.*

The One Rule That Overrides All Others:

A compliant proposal that answers the agency's question clearly and specifically will always outscore a creative proposal that makes evaluators work to find the compliance. **Be clear. Be specific. Be compliant. Make it easy for the evaluator to give you the highest score.** Everything else in this guide is in service of that single principle.